

OFFICIAL PROGRAMME

Merge Film Festival 2026



1–4 October 2026

MASSAGNO

5 October · Bellinzona · Outside the festival

Thursday

1 OCTOBER 2026

One evening on the big screen.

20:30

20:30–23:00 · CINEMA LUX, MAIN AUDITORIUM

CHF 15.– / conc. 10.–

Opening ceremony • Memory of Princess Mumbi

The festival opens and the film begins immediately afterwards in the same auditorium. One ticket for the whole evening.

Competition screenings, retrospectives, opening and closing ceremonies: CHF 15.– per event, CHF 30.– day pass.

Students and over-65s: CHF 10.– and CHF 20.–. All other events are free.

Accreditation includes one free seat per screening.

Friday

2 OCTOBER 2026

Private school sessions in the morning, followed by the first two competition programmes, the discussion and the Swiss awards. Food and drinks in Piazza Grande from 18:00 to 01:00.

09:00	09:00–13:00 · MASSAGNO SCHOOLS, AULA MAGNA AND CLASSROOMS 1–3 Workshops for middle schools · Luca Botturi Schools only
10:00	10:00–12:00 · CINEMA LUX, MAIN AUDITORIUM Retrospective · WALL·E CHF 15.– / conc. 10.– Andrew Stanton, Pixar, 2008 · 98 min.
10:00	10:00–11:45 · CINEMA LUX, COSMO AUDITORIUM Masterclass for arts high schools · Antonella Autuori Schools only
14:00	14:00–15:30 · CINEMA LUX, COSMO AUDITORIUM Masterclass for science high schools · Stefano Peduzzi Schools only
14:00	14:00–15:30 · CINEMA LUX, MAIN AUDITORIUM In competition · Programme 1 CHF 15.– / conc. 10.– Seven short films, ≈ 60 min. Followed by a Q&A with the directors in person.
17:00	17:00–18:00 · CINEMA LUX, MAIN AUDITORIUM FORMA APERTA · Where does the creative process live? Free admission Open talk and launch of FORMA APERTA, with Felix Bachmann, Kevin Merz, Manuela Bachmann and Simona Gamba.
18:30	18:30–20:00 · CINEMA LUX, MAIN AUDITORIUM Discussion with Alessandro Bavari and Dario Cirrincione Free admission Screening works by Alessandro Bavari: Cronache di Mare (WORLD PREMIERE), Artefatti, Raw War, The Freakpoint Range, UNKNOWN QUANTUM OBJECTS.
20:45	20:45 · CINEMA LUX, MAIN AUDITORIUM Swiss Innovator Award · Swiss Press Award Included with the Programme 2 ticket
21:00	21:00–22:00 · CINEMA LUX, MAIN AUDITORIUM In competition · Programme 2 CHF 15.– / conc. 10.– Six short films, ≈ 60 min., with a Q&A with the directors in person.

Competition screenings, retrospectives, opening and closing ceremonies: CHF 15.– per event, CHF 30.– day pass.

Students and over-65s: CHF 10.– and CHF 20.–. All other events are free.

Accreditation includes one free seat per screening.

Saturday

3 OCTOBER 2026

The busiest day: three competition programmes, a roundtable, a talk and the Critics' Award. Food and drinks in Piazza Grande from 10:00 to 01:00.

10:00	● 10:00–12:00 · CINEMA LUX, MAIN AUDITORIUM Retrospective · title to be announced We'll announce it soon. CHF 15.– / conc. 10.–
10:00	● 10:00–13:00 · MASSAGNO SCHOOLS, AULA MAGNA CISA and USI lecture · Alessandro Bavari and Marco Longo Schools only
13:30	● 13:30–15:00 · CINEMA LUX, MAIN AUDITORIUM In competition · Programme 3 Eight short films, ≈ 60 min. Followed by a Q&A with the directors in person. CHF 15.– / conc. 10.–
14:00	● 14:00–15:00 · CINEMA LUX, COSMO AUDITORIUM Roundtable With Marco Zaffalon, Colin Porlezza, Javisth Chabria and Pierre Alexandre Tremblay. Moderated by Felix Bachmann (Centro Generativo). In collaboration with USI. Free admission
15:30	● 15:30–17:00 · CINEMA LUX, MAIN AUDITORIUM In competition · Programme 4 Eight short films, ≈ 60 min. Followed by a Q&A with the directors in person. CHF 15.– / conc. 10.–
17:30	● 17:30–19:00 · CINEMA LUX, MAIN AUDITORIUM Talk · Javisth Chabria and Kevin B. Lee Moderated by Felix Bachmann (Centro Generativo). In collaboration with USI. Free admission
21:00	● 21:00–22:30 · CINEMA LUX, MAIN AUDITORIUM Critics' Award and In competition · Programme 5 The Critics' Award, followed by seven short films, ≈ 60 min., with a Q&A with the directors in person. CHF 15.– / conc. 10.–

Competition screenings, retrospectives, opening and closing ceremonies: CHF 15.– per event, CHF 30.– day pass.

Students and over-65s: CHF 10.– and CHF 20.–. All other events are free.

Accreditation includes one free seat per screening.

Sunday

4 OCTOBER 2026

The final retrospective, followed by the awards ceremony and a screening of the winning films immediately afterwards.

10:00

10:00–12:00 · CINEMA LUX, MAIN AUDITORIUM

Retrospective · title to be announced

CHF 15.– / conc. 10.–

We'll announce it soon.

15:00

15:00–16:00 · CINEMA LUX, MAIN AUDITORIUM

Awards ceremony and screening of the winning films

CHF 15.– / conc. 10.–

The awards are presented, immediately followed by a screening of the winning films.

Competition screenings, retrospectives, opening and closing ceremonies: CHF 15.– per event, CHF 30.– day pass.

Students and over-65s: CHF 10.– and CHF 20.–. All other events are free.

Accreditation includes one free seat per screening.

Monday

5 OCTOBER 2026

The day after the closing ceremony the festival travels to Bellinzona as a guest of the Swiss {ai} Weeks. This one is outside the festival programme: free, in another town, and with a sign-up of its own.

16:00

16:00 · PALAZZO CIVICO, BELLINZONA · COUNCIL CHAMBER

Swiss {ai} Weeks · Memoria Viva

Free · sign-up required

Stories, voices and archives in the age of artificial intelligence. Merge brings a best of the 2026 selection, and artistic directors Dario Cirrincione and Francesco Poloni are in the room.

PROGRAMME

- 16:00** Welcome and opening remarks · Gaetano Biondo
- 16:15** Biography Library · Claudio Brignole
- 16:45** From Giorgino to Memoria Viva · Roberto Mazzantini
- 17:15** Screening · Giorgino and the dragon known as Oblivion
- 17:30** Discussion

Registration required: luma.com/jhp0ct2s

Guest event, outside the festival · Free · sign-up required

Memoria Viva is organised by Mazzantini & Associati SA and Biography Library within the Swiss {ai} Weeks, under the patronage of the Città di Bellinzona. Sign-up is confirmed by the organisers.